

Here is a detailed list of functionality/behaviours in Windows 11 that many users and privacy-advocates regard as bordering on (or arguably fitting) the definition of “spyware.” I’ll also include what is known about each item (what data is collected/used), and where applicable what control or mitigation is available. **This is not a legal judgement** of Windows 11 as spyware, but a compilation of features that raise spyware-type privacy concerns.

What counts as “spyware” behaviour?

Before the list: by “spyware” I mean software that collects or transmits user data in a covert, unexpected, or persistent way, especially if it’s difficult for a user to opt-out, lacks transparency, or is used for profiling/monitoring rather than strictly for user benefit. Many of the items below raise one or more of these concerns.

Issues/subjects in Windows 11

1. Telemetry / Diagnostic Data Collection

- Windows collects device & system data (hardware info, OS version, installed apps, driver status, crash/error reports) and sends it back to Microsoft.
- Some of this data is labelled “required,” but additional data (optional diagnostics) may include app usage, browser data, etc.
- The ability to fully disable telemetry is limited (especially on Home editions).
- Risk: Even if “optional” is off, “required” telemetry still runs; the volume and detail of data (especially if linked to account/device) can amount to behaviour similar to spyware.

2. Activity History & Cross-Device Syncing

- Windows can track which apps you open, which files you access, your “Recent items,” etc., and sync this across devices via your Microsoft account.
- This means your usage patterns are recorded, and potentially associated with your identity (if using a Microsoft account).
- Users may not realize how comprehensively this is happening, or how to disable it.

3. Personalised Ads / Advertising ID / Profiling

- Windows/Edge assign an advertising ID (or similar identifiers) for apps, and use usage data for ad-targeting, recommendations or “tailored experiences”.
- The option to limit this is present, but may be buried or require multiple toggles.
- Risk: If your device/usage is profiled, that is a behaviour akin to spyware/analytics for commercial ends.

4. Location / “Find My Device” / Device Identifiers

- Windows uses location data (for features like Find My Device, or more accurate local services) and may also collect device identifiers and network info.
- The concern is that location + device identity + usage behaviour gives a rich profile of a user’s movements and habits.

5. Voice, Inking & Typing Data

- Features like dictation, voice recognition, handwriting/inking personalization may send usage/voice/pen input data to Microsoft for “improvement” of services.
- As one article states: “samples are uploaded for improved recognition (allegedly decoupled from personal identity)” which introduces risk.
- Risk: Potentially sensitive input data (voice/handwriting/typing) being transmitted externally.

6. Default Microsoft Account & Cloud Integration Encouragement

- Windows 11 requires the use of a Microsoft account; many features (syncing, profiles, cloud backup) revolve around it. That means data is linked to your account identity.
- Risk: Linking local OS usage to a cloud identity expands the scope of what can be collected and correlated.

7. Lack of Full Transparency & Difficulty Opting-Out

- While Microsoft provides settings, many users find them non-intuitive, scattered, or unclear about what exactly is collected.
- Some data collection cannot be turned off (or only in limited versions).
- Risk: Even if not malicious, the “hidden” or default-enabled nature of collection makes it more spyware-like.

8. Third-Party Data Sharing / Services Contacted

- Some investigations show Windows 11 connecting to many servers (Microsoft's and third-party) after installation, raising questions over what is sent and to whom.
- Risk: Data flows to external parties beyond purely OS update/security scope, approaching third-party analytics/tracking.

9. Usage Behaviour Data Used for Recommendations / OS Behaviour

- Windows uses collected data to provide “tailored experiences” (e.g., recommending apps, settings, suggestions) based on your usage behaviour.
- Risk: This is not just diagnostic data—it is behaviour-based personalization, which overlaps with tracking.

10. Data Linked Across Services / Devices

- Because of the ecosystem (Microsoft account + cloud sync + edge browser + Office apps + Windows OS) data from multiple sources can be merged into a larger profile.
- Risk: The richer the profile, the closer it resembles what we commonly consider “spyware” behaviour (monitoring, profiling, linking identity to actions).

Summary Table

Feature / Behaviour	What is collected or done	Why it raises spyware-type concern
Telemetry / Diagnostic data	Device specs, app usage, crash logs	Persistent data upload, limited opt-out
Activity history & sync	Apps opened, files accessed, usage patterns	Behaviour tracking, cross-device linking
Advertising ID & profiling	ID assigned, app usage tied to ads	Commercial profiling, targeted recommendations
Location & device identifiers	Location, device IDs, network info	Movement tracking, linking to user identity
Voice / inking / typing data	Speech input, handwriting input, keystroke patterns	Sensitive personal data, external processing
Microsoft account / cloud integration	Usage linked to user identity across devices	Rich profile linking and sync of private data

Windows11 Privacy Issues

Feature / Behaviour	What is collected or done	Why it raises spyware-type concern
Transparency / control issues	Scattered settings, defaults on, some data cannot be disabled	Lack of user agency, hidden collection
Data flows to third parties	OS contacting many external endpoints	Unclear what is sent/received, third-party analytics
Behaviour-based OS personalization	Recommendations based on usage	Tracking not just for diagnostics but for influencing behaviour
Cross-service/device linking	Data merged from browser, Office, OS, cloud	Large scale profile creation, high privacy risk

What you can do / mitigate

- In Settings → *Privacy & security* → *Diagnostics & feedback*: turn **Send optional diagnostic data** off.
 - Turn off or limit **Activity history** (e.g., “Store my activity history on this device”).
 - In Privacy settings → *General* or *Advertising ID*: disable apps showing personalised ads.
 - Use a **local account** instead of a Microsoft account, where possible, to reduce cloud-linking.
 - Review and disable location services (Settings → Privacy → Location).
 - For professional users: Use Group Policy or Registry tweaks (e.g., disable “Allow Telemetry” policy) if you run Pro/Enterprise editions.
 - Clear stored diagnostic data using built-in tools (e.g., Diagnostic Data Viewer).
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Final thoughts

While Microsoft states that much of the data collection is to keep the system secure, up-to-date, and performing well, the volume, default settings, behaviour-based profiling, and cloud/linkage aspects mean that many people reasonably consider these features to **approach spyware behaviour**. Some key questions remain about consent clarity, transparency, opt-out completeness, and third-party sharing.